

Li Zeng

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RESEARCH AREAS	Data science, machine learning, computational social science, crisis informatics, health informatics, social network analysis, natural language processing, social media and online data collection.
EDUCATION	University of Washington, Seattle, WA, USA2017 – 2022 <i>Ph.D. in Information Science</i> - PhD Committee: - Emma S. Spiro (Chair), Zack Almquist, Nicholas Weber, Robert M. Mason, Gary Hsieh (GSR) University of Washington, Seattle, WA, USA2014 – 2017 <i>Master of Science in Information Science</i> Communication University of China, Beijing, China2010 – 2014 <i>Bachelor of Administration in Information Management and Information Systems</i> - Graduated with College Honors - Cumulative GPA: 3.81 / 4.00
APPOINTMENTS	Tilburg University, Tilburg, NetherlandsMar 2022 – present <i>Assistant Professor</i>, Department of Methodology and Statistics
AWARDS & HONORS	- Best Paper Award - <i>Human-Computer Interaction International Conference, Las Vegas</i>2018 - Lee Dirks Best Paper Award Finalist - <i>iConference Wuhan, China</i>2017 - University of Washington Top Scholar Award2014 - Undergraduate Graduation Honor of Beijing Municipal Commission of Education2014 - Excellent Student Award of Beijing2013 - Excellent Student Award of Communication University of China2011 & 2012 - Excellent Student Leader of Communication University of China2012
FELLOWSHIPS & GRANTS	- Tilburg University Starter GrantJan 2024 - Tilburg Research Infrastructure MicrograntOct 2023 - Center for Statistics and the Social Sciences Travel GrantDec 2015 & May 2016 - William & Ruth Gerberding Endowed FellowshipSep 2014 - Tokyo Broadcasting System Television Inc. ScholarshipMay 2013 - China Central Television ScholarshipDec 2012 - First-class Scholarship of Communication University of ChinaDec 2012 - National ScholarshipNov 2011 Awarded by Ministry of Education of The People's Republic of China
PUBLICATIONS	Zeng, L., Ma, S., Kim, S., & Sturlese, G. (2026, May). Decentralized Diffusion: Decomposing Information Diffusion in Federated Social Networks. In <i>Proceedings of the International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media</i> (Vol. 20, No. 1, pp. 2676-2688). Zeng, L., & Hang, Z. (2026). Health Comes at a Hidden Cost: Strategic Pricing and Equity in Heart Supplement Markets. <i>Proceedings of the 59th Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences (HICSS 2026)</i> (pp. 1329–1338).

Zeng, L., & Hang, Z. (2026). The Cost of Inaccessibility: Retail Discrimination and Mobility-Constrained Consumers. *Proceedings of the 59th Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences (HICSS 2026)* (pp. 6886–6895).

Wójcik, K., **Zeng, L.**, & Ma, S. (2025). Real Name, Real Face, Real Talk? Anonymity and Toxicity on Mastodon. *Workshop Proceedings of the 19th International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media*. <https://doi.org/10.36190/2025.07>

Kim, S., **Zeng, L.**, Ma, S., & Sturlese, G. (2025). Sentiment Dynamics and Shifts across Instances on Mastodon. *Workshop Proceedings of the 19th International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media*. <https://doi.org/10.36190/2025.45>

Gong, X., Ren, J., **Zeng, L.**, Xing, R. (2022). How KOLs Influence Consumer Purchase Intention in Short Video Platforms: Mediating Effects of Emotional Response and Virtual Touch. *International Journal of Information Systems in the Service Sector (IJISSS)*, 14(1), 1-23..

Zeng, L., Dailey, D. , Mohamed, O., Starbird, K., and Spiro, E.S.. “Detecting Journalism in the Age of Social Media: Three Experiments in Classifying Journalists on Twitter,” in *Proceedings of the 13rd International Conference on Web and Social Media (ICWSM)*, Munich, Germany, Jun 2019.

Zeng, L., Almquist, Z.W. and Spiro, E.S.. “‘Friending’ in Online Fitness Communities: Exploring Activity-Based Online Network Structure,” in *Proceedings of the 52nd Hawaii International Conference on Systems Science (HICSS)*. *IEEE Computer Society*, Maui, Hawaii, USA, Jan 2019.

Almquist, Z. W., Arya, S., **Zeng, L.**, and Spiro, E. (2018). Unbiased Sampling of Users from (Online) Activity Data. *Field Methods*, 1525822X18799426.

Zeng, L., Almquist, Z.W. and Spiro, E.S., 2018, July. “Stay Connected and Keep Motivated: Modeling Activity Level of Exercise in an Online Fitness Community,” in *International Conference on Social Computing and Social Media* (pp. 137-147). Springer, Cham. [Best Paper Award](#).

Zeng, L., Almquist, Z., and Spiro, E.S., “Let’s Workout! Exploring Social Exercise in an Online Fitness Community,” in *Proceedings of iConference 2017*, Wuhan, China, Mar 2017. [Lee Dirks Best Paper Award Finalist \(Top 5 Papers\)](#).

Zeng, L., Starbird, K., and Spiro, E.S., (2016), “#Unconfirmed: Classifying Rumor Stance in Crisis-Related Social Media Messages,” in *Proceedings of the 10th International Conference on Web and Social Media (ICWSM)*, Cologne, Germany, May 2016.

Zeng, L., Starbird, K., and Spiro, E.S., (2016), “Rumors at the Speed of Light? Modeling the Rate of Rumor Transmission during Crisis,” in *Proceedings of the 49th Hawaii International Conference on Systems Science (HICSS)*. *IEEE Computer Society*, Kauai, Hawaii, USA, Jan 2016.

Ren, J., Zhuo, X., **Zeng, L.**, and Li, B., (2013), “A Design of Mobile Payments Business Model Based on Value Network,” in *Proceedings of the 20th International Conference on Industrial Engineering and Engineering Management (IE&EM2013)*, Baotou, China, Aug 2013.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Zeng, L., Ma, S., Kim, S., & Sturlese, G. (May 2026). “Decentralized Diffusion: Decomposing Information Diffusion in Federated Social Networks,” The 20th International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media, Los Angeles, USA.

Sturlese, G., Kim, S., **Zeng, L.**, and Ma, S. (July 2025), “Decentralized Discourse: Analyzing Sentiment Diffusion of the 2023 Gaza–Israel Conflict Across Mastodon Instances,” poster presented at the 11th Annual International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2 2025), Linköping, Sweden.

Wójcik, K., **Zeng, L.**, and Ma, S. (June 2025). “Real Name, Real Face, Real Talk? Anonymity and Toxicity on Mastodon, COMPASS 2025 — The 1st International Workshop on Computational Approaches to Content Moderation and Platform Governance at the 19th International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media, Copenhagen, Denmark.

Kim, S., **Zeng, L.**, Ma, S., and Sturlese, G. (June 2025). “Sentiment Dynamics and Shifts across Instances on Mastodon,” Next-Generation and Alternative Social Media Workshop 2025 at the 19th International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media, Copenhagen, Denmark.

Zubair, S., and **Zeng, L.** (December 2023). “Enhancing Polarity Classification in Social Media Texts: The Role of Emojis and Hashtags,” the Annual Meeting of the ASIS&T Asia Pacific Chapter, Beijing, China.

Zeng, L., Dailey, D. , Mohamed, O., Starbird, K., and Spiro, E.S.. (June 2019). “Detecting Journalism in the Age of Social Media: Three Experiments in Classifying Journalists on Twitter,” the 13rd International Conference on Web and Social Media, Munich, Germany.

Zeng, L., Almquist, Z., and Spiro, E.S., (July 2018), “Stay Connected and Keep Motivated: Modeling Activity Level of Exercise in an Online Fitness Community,” the 20th International Conference on Human-Computer Interaction (HCII 2018), Las Vegas, Nevada, USA.

Zeng, L., Almquist, Z., and Spiro, E.S., (July 2018), “Gender Differences in Social Exercise in an Online Fitness Community,” the 4th Annual International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2 2018), Evanston, Illinois, USA.

Zeng, L., Almquist, Z., and Spiro, E.S., (March 2017), “Let’s Workout! Exploring Social Exercise in an Online Fitness Community,” iConference 2017, Wuhan, China.

Zeng, L., Almquist, Z., and Spiro, E.S., (November 2016), “Let’s Workout! Exploring Social Exercise in an Online Fitness Community,” Activity-based Networks Workshop in the 8th International Conference on Social Informatics (SocInfo 2016), Bellevue, WA, USA.

Zeng, L., Nied, A.C., Walls, L., Robinson, J., Starbird, K., and Spiro, E.S., (June 2016), “Misinformation Detection on Social Media Spaces during Crisis Events,” The 2nd Annual International Conference on Computational Social Science, Evanston, Illinois, USA.

Zeng, L., Starbird, K., and Spiro, E.S., (May 2016), “#Unconfirmed: Classifying Rumor Stance in Crisis-Related Social Media Messages,” The 10th International Conference on Web and Social Media, Cologne, Germany.

Zeng, L., Starbird, K., and Spiro, E.S., (April 2016), “Modeling Rumor Diffusion on Social Media during Crisis Events,” The 36th Sunbelt Network Conference (INSNA), Newport Beach, California, USA.

Zeng, L., Starbird, K., and Spiro, E.S., (January 2016), “Rumors at the Speed of Light? Modeling the Rate of Rumor Transmission during Crisis,” The 49th Hawaii International Conference on Systems Science, Kauai, Hawaii, USA.

TEACHING

500189-B-6: Introduction to Data Science ; Tilburg University, Tilburg, Netherlands

- Block 4, 2022 - present; Lecturer and Course Coordinator

This undergraduate course introduces students to the foundations of data science with an emphasis on practical application using R. Topics include data cleaning and visualization, exploratory data analysis, supervised and unsupervised learning, and model evaluation. I am fully responsible for course design, lectures, and computer labs, and I developed all teaching materials including lecture slides, assignments, and coding exercises.

JBIO30: Data Mining and Machine Learning; Eindhoven University of Technology, Eindhoven, Netherlands

- Block 2, 2022 - present; Lecturer

This undergraduate course introduces key concepts and techniques in data mining, with a focus on practical model implementation and evaluation in Python. I serve as co-lecturer and am primarily responsible for the supervised learning component, covering topics such as logistic regression, Naïve Bayes, support vector machines, decision trees, and neural networks.

**OTHER
TEACHING**

INFO 300: Research Methods; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Autumn Quarter, 2021; Lecturer and Course Coordinator

INFO 201: Technical Foundations; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Spring Quarter, 2021; Teaching Assistant

INFO 201: Data Science II: Machine Learning and Econometrics; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Winter Quarter, 2020; Teaching Assistant

INFO 474: Interactive Information Visualization; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Autumn Quarter, 2020; Teaching Assistant

IMT 575 C Sp 20: Data Science III: Scaling, Applications, And Ethics; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Spring Quarter, 2020; Teaching Assistant

IMT 574 A: Data Science II: Machine Learning and Econometrics; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Winter Quarter, 2020; Teaching Assistant

IMT 547: Social Media Data Mining and Analysis; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Autumn Quarter, 2018; Pre-doctoral Lecturer and Course Coordinator

INFO 370: Introduction to Data Science; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Autumn Quarter, 2017; Pre-doctoral Lecturer

IMT 574: Data Science II: Machine Learning And Econometrics

- Winter Quarter, 2019; Teaching Assistant

INFX 573: Data Science I: Theoretical Foundations; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Autumn Quarter, 2016; Teaching Assistant
- Autumn Quarter, 2015; Teaching Assistant

INFO 371: Core Methods In Data Science; University of Washington, Seattle, WA

- Spring Quarter, 2016; Lab Teaching Assistant

**ACADEMIC
SERVICE**

Program Coordinator, Bachelor's Major in Psychological Methods and Data Analysis, Department of Methodology and Statistics, Tilburg University

- Responsible for curriculum planning, teaching coordination, and program evaluation.

Thesis Coordinator, Bachelor's Major in Psychological Methods and Data Analysis, Department of Methodology and Statistics, Tilburg University

- Oversee thesis procedures, topic matching, and supervision quality across the major program.

Peer Review Service

- The International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media (ICWSM)
- The International Conference on Social Informatics (SocInfo)
- The Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences (HICSS)
- Psychometrika
- ASIS&T Annual Meeting (ASIS&T Asia Pacific Chapter)

SKILLS

Analysis & Programming:

- Python, R, HTML, JavaScript, Java, C++, C, SPSS

Database:

- SQL, MongoDB

Data Visualization:

- D3.js, Tableau, Gephi, Crystal Xcelsius

Other:

- L^AT_EX

